



BUILT BY AFRICANS
FOR AFRICA

HR TRAINING

MODULE 4

Employee Relations

A Traction Outsourcing Limited HR Training Resource
Student Guide for HR practitioners and hiring teams

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1 Employee Turnover

Part One: Employee Retention

Organizations must try to ensure that good performers want to stay with the organization and that employees whose performance is chronically low are encouraged— or forced—to leave. Both of these challenges involve employee turnover; that is, employees leaving the organization. When the organization initiates the turnover (often with employees who would prefer to stay), the result is involuntary turnover. Examples include terminating an employee for drug use or laying off employees during a downturn. Most organizations use the word termination to refer only to a discharge related to a discipline problem, but some organizations call any involuntary turnover a termination. When the employees initiate the turnover (often when the organization would prefer to keep them), it is voluntary turnover. Employees may leave to retire or to take a job with a different organization. Typically, the employees who leave voluntarily are either the organization's worst performers, who quit before they are fired, or its best performers, who can most easily find attractive new opportunities.

Turnover is classified in a number of ways. One classification uses the following categories, although the two types are not mutually exclusive:

Voluntary Turnover	Involuntary Turnover
• Avoidable turnover • Pay • Assignment • Leadership • Performance	• Dismissal / Discharge turnover • Discipline • Performance
• Unavoidable turnover • Retirement • Career • Health • Family • Education	• Downsizing • Reduction in force, RIF • Close down

Turnover Rate: (number of employees leaving / average number of employees) x 100

1.1. Voluntary Turnover

Voluntary turnover too can be caused by many factors, some of which are not employer controlled. Common voluntary turnover causes include job dissatisfaction, pay and benefits levels, supervision, geography, and personal/family reasons. Career opportunities in other firms, when employees receive unsolicited contacts, may lead to turnover for individuals, especially those in highly specialized jobs such as IT. Voluntary turnover may increase with the size of the organization, most likely because larger firms are less effective in preventing turnover and have more employees who are inclined to move. Voluntary turnover, in turn, is broken down into avoidable and unavoidable turnover.

1.1.1. Avoidable Turnover

Employees leave for reasons that could be influenced by the employer. Avoidable turnover is that which potentially could have been prevented by certain organization actions, such as a pay raise or a new job assignment.

1.1.2. Unavoidable Turnover

Unavoidable turnover represents employee quits that the organization probably could not have prevented, such as people who quit and withdraw from workforce through retirement or returning to school. Other examples of unavoidable turnover are people who quit due to: dual career problems, pursuit of a new and different career, health problems that require taking a different type of job, child care and elder care responsibilities, and leaving the country. Even though some turnover is inevitable, employers recognize that reducing turnover saves money, and that they must address the turnover that is controllable. Organizations are better able to keep employees if they deal with the concerns of those employees that might lead to the controllable turnover.

1.2. Involuntary Turnover

Involuntary turnover is triggered at all levels by employers terminating workers due to organizational policies and work rule violations, excessive absenteeism, performance standards that are not met by employees, and other issues. Involuntary turnover is split into discharge and downsizing types.

1.2.1. Discharge turnover

Discharge turnover is aimed at the individual employee, due to discipline and/or job performance problem. You can fire, dismissal, or discharge -- an employee. Typically, an employee is fired for doing something that's not in the best interests of your business, which is known as being fired "for cause," so the term has a negative connotation. When an employee is fired, his employment ceases either immediately or -- as of a certain date -- at the employer's discretion. When an employee is fired for cause, in some states, this can prevent the employee

from making a claim for unemployment benefits. Consequently, you should carefully document the circumstances that resulted in the employee being fired, so that you can support your case that he shouldn't receive unemployment. Typically, companies pay the employee's unemployment insurance, so you want as few claims as possible to hit your policy.

Terminating an employee simply means that you end the employment relationship. In general, "discharge" can be a synonym for the more common label "termination" when releasing an employee involuntarily from a job. However, discharge is often used in the legal phrase "wrongful discharge." When you fire somebody in violation of local, state or federal anti-discrimination or anti-retaliation laws, you face a potential "wrongful discharge" lawsuit.

1.2.2. Downsizing turnover

Downsizing turnover typically targets groups of employees and is also known as reduction in force (RIF) caused by organizational restructuring or cost-reduction program. Sometimes, you need to let an employee go, based on unexpected factors, such as a downturn in sales that resulted from a recently passed law. This type of work separation is involuntary, also called Lay off, but it is not the fault of the employee. When an employee is laid off, typically, she has access to her unemployment benefits while she searches for a new job.

Termination is end of any service contract. It includes Dismissal and Discharge. Discharge is end of service contract with mutual understanding. Dismissal or firing is generally thought to be the fault of the employee, whereas a layoff is generally done for business reasons (for instance a business slowdown or an economic downturn) outside the employee's performance.

1.3. Causes of Turnover

1.3.1. Voluntary turnover

Voluntary turnover depends on three factors:

- Desirability of leaving: low job satisfaction, shocks to employee, and personal (non-job) reason.
- Ease of leaving: favorable labor market conditions, general & transferable KSAOs, and low cost of leaving.
- Alternatives: internal new job possibilities and external job offers

1.3.2. Discharge turnover

Discharge turnover is due to extremely poor person/job matches, particularly the mismatch between job requirements and KSAOs. One form of the mismatch involves the employee failing to follow rules and procedures. The other form of discharge turnover involves unacceptable job performance.

1.3.3. Downsizing turnover

Downsizing turnover is a reflection of a staffing level mismatch in which the organization actually is, or is projected to be, overstaffed. In other words, the head count available exceeds the head count required, which may be due to poor workforce planning.

1.4. Functional or Dysfunctional Turnover

Not all turnover is negative for organizations; on the contrary, functional turnover represents a positive change. Some workforce losses are desirable, especially if those who leave are lower-performing, less reliable, and/or disruptive individuals. Of course, dysfunctional turnover also occurs. That happens when key individuals leave, often at crucial times.

1.4.1. Functional Turnover

Lower-performing or disruptive employees leave

1.4.2. Dysfunctional Turnover

Key individuals and high performers leave at critical times. For example, a software project leader who leaves in the middle of a system upgrade in order to take a promotion at another firm could cause the system upgrade timeline to slip due to the difficulty of replacing the employee and could also lead other software specialists in the firm to seek out and accept jobs at competitive firms.

1.5. Turnover and “Churn”

Hiring new workers while laying off others is called churn. This practice raises a paradox in which employers complain about not being able to find skilled workers while they are laying off others. As organizations face economic and financial problems that result in layoffs, the remaining employees are more likely to consider jobs at other firms. In this situation, turnover is more likely to occur, and efforts are needed to keep existing employees. HR actions such as information sharing, opportunities for more training/learning, and emphasis on job significance can be helpful in lowering turnover intentions of individuals.

1.6. Measuring Employee Turnover

The turnover rate for an organization can be computed as a monthly or yearly cost. The following formula, in which separations means departures from the organization, is widely used:

Turnover Rate: $(\text{number of employees leaving} / \text{average number of employees}) * 100$

Other areas to be included in calculating detailed turnover costs are also available. Some of the most common areas considered include the following:

1.6.1. Separation costs

HR staff and supervisory time, pay rates to prevent separations, exit interview time, unemployment expenses, legal fees for separations challenged, accrued vacation expenditures, continued health benefits, and others.

1.6.2. Vacancy costs

Temporary help, contract and consulting firm usage, existing employee overtime, and other costs until the person is replaced.

1.6.3. Replacement costs

Recruiting and advertising expenses, search fees, HR interviewer and staff time and salaries, employee referral fees, relocation and moving costs, supervisor and managerial time and salaries, employment testing costs, reference checking fees, pre-employment medical expenses, relocation costs, and others.

1.6.4. Training costs

Paid orientation time, training staff time and pay, costs of training materials, supervisor and manager time and salaries, coworker 'coaching' time and pay, and others.

1.6.5. Hidden/indirect costs

Costs that are not obvious, such as reduced productivity, decreased customer service, additional unexpected employee turnover, missed project deadlines, and others.

Please be noted that not all turnover is negative. Turnover of low performers should be considered positive. There may be an "optimal" amount of useful turnover in order to replace low performers and add part-time or contract workers with special capabilities to enhance workforce performance. HR professionals should take actions to reduce negative turnover and to address the retention of key employees.

1.7. Employee Attrition

Attrition is the normal life cycle of employment. Employees who move, retire, pass away or leave the company to raise a family or attend school represent the usual ebb and flow of staffers through a business. In other words, when it comes to attrition, employees are leaving not because they have a problem with your company or their jobs – it's a matter of life unfolding. Attrition tends to be higher in companies located in transient cities and in organizations that hire older employees as a matter of practice.

2 Employee Retention

Retention of employees as human resources is part of HR staffing and planning efforts. Turnover, as the opposite of retention, often has been seen as a routine HR matter requiring records and reports. However, what was once a bothersome detail has become a substantial HR issue for many employers. Thus, organizations are being forced to study why employees leave and why they stay. Sometimes an individual in the HR area is assigned to specifically focus on retention to ensure that it receives high priority.

Keeping good employees is a challenge that all organizations share and that becomes even more difficult as labor markets change. Unfortunately, some myths have arisen about what it takes to retain employees. Some of the most prevalent myths and realities are as follows:

- Money is the main reason people leave. Money certainly is a vital HR tool, and if people feel they are being paid inadequately, they may be more likely to leave. But if they are paid close to the competitive level they expect, other parts of the job become more important.
- Hiring has little to do with retention. This is not true. Recruiting and selecting the people who fit the jobs and who are less likely to leave in the first place, and then orienting them to the company, can greatly increase retention. It is important to select for retention.
- If you train people, you are only training them for another employer. Developing skills in employees may indeed make them more marketable, but it also tends to improve retention. When an employer provides employees with training and development assistance, job satisfaction may increase and employees are more likely to stay, particularly if they see more future opportunities internally.
- Do not be concerned about retention during organizational change. That is exactly the time to worry about retention. Although some people's jobs may have to be cut because of economic organizational factors, the remaining employees that the company would like to keep may have the most opportunity and reason to leave voluntarily. For example, during a merger or acquisition, most workers are concerned about job security and their employer's future. If they do not feel a part of the new organization early on, many may leave or evaluate alternatives.
- If solid performers want to leave, the company cannot hold them. Employees are best viewed as "free agents," who indeed can leave when they want. The key to keeping solidly performing employees is to create an environment in which they want to stay and grow.

Because both people and jobs are so varied, managers and HR professionals need to realize that individuals may remain or leave their employment for both job-related and personal reasons. For instance, if employees choose to leave an organization for family reasons (e.g., because a

spouse is transferring or to raise children), there may be a limited number of actions the employer can take to keep them on the job. However, there are significant actions that an employer can take to retain employees in many other circumstances. The figure below illustrates some of these “drivers” of retention, or areas in which employers can take action to strengthen the possibility of keeping employees.



Phillips, J.J. & Connell, A.O. (2011). Managing Employee Retention. London, UK: Routledge.

The actual reasons that people stay or leave vary according to job groupings, industry and organizational issues, geographical global aspects, and other factors. For instance, a survey of executives by a global staffing and recruiting firm found that the most common factors that caused satisfactory employees to quit their jobs were unhappiness with management, limited career advancements and recognition, insufficient pay and benefits, and job boredom. This survey illustrates that many of the factors involved in retention drivers are organizational and management factors within the employer's control.

2.1. Organizational and Management Factors

A number of organizational/management factors influence individuals in their decisions to stay with or leave their employers. Organizations that have clearly established goals and hold managers and employees accountable for accomplishing results are viewed as better places to work, especially by individuals wishing to progress both financially and career-wise. Further, effective management provides the resources necessary for employees to perform their jobs well. These factors reflect workplace commitment by employees, which leads to more positive organizational views in the industry and communities.

Other organizational components that affect employee retention are related to the management of the organization. Some organizations see external events as threatening, whereas others see changes as challenges requiring responses. The latter approach can be a source of competitive advantage, especially if an organization is in a growing, dynamic industry. Another organizational factor that can affect employee job performance and potential turnover intentions is “organizational politics.” This can include managerial favoritism, having to be involved in undesirable activities, taking credit for what others do, and other actions that occur in many departments and organizational settings.

A final factor affecting how employees view their organizations is the quality of organizational leadership. Often, leaders have an identified strategic plan that guides how the firm responds to changes. If a firm is not effectively managed, then employees may be disappointed by the ineffective responses and inefficiencies they deal with in their jobs. A survey of 700 workers identified that “bad bosses” who do not give employees recognition for accomplishments or who fail to keep promises can lead to almost 40% of the workers being dissatisfied and more likely to look for other jobs.

2.2. Work Relationships

Work relationships that affect employee retention include supervisory/management support and coworker relations. A supervisor or manager builds positive relationships and aids retention by being fair and nondiscriminatory, allowing work flexibility and work-family balancing, giving feedback that recognizes employee efforts and performance, and supporting career planning and development.

Additionally, many individuals build close relationships with coworkers. Such work-related friendships do not appear on employee records, but these relationships can be an important signal that a workplace is positive. Overall, what this means is that it is not just where people work, but also with whom they work, that affects employee retention. If individuals are not linked with or do not relate well to their coworkers, there is greater likelihood for turnover to occur.

2.3. Job and Work-Life

Many individuals have seen a decline in job security during the past decade. All the downsizings, layoffs, mergers and acquisitions, and organizational restructurings have affected employee loyalty and retention. As coworkers experience layoffs and job reductions, the anxiety levels of the remaining employees rise. Consequently, employees start thinking about leaving before they too get cut. Organizations in which job continuity and security are high tend to have higher retention rates.

Some jobs are considered “good” and others are thought to be “bad,” but not all people agree on which jobs are which. As mentioned previously, the design of jobs and peoples' preferences can vary significantly. Job design factors that can impact retention include the following:

- A knowledge, skills, and abilities mismatch, either through overqualification or underqualification, can lead to turnover.
- Job accomplishments and workload demands that are dissatisfying or stressful may impact performance and lead to turnover.

- Both timing of work schedules and geographic locations may contribute to burnout of some individuals but not others.
- The ability of employees to balance work and life requirements affects their job performance and retention.

Numerous examples could be given on how each of these items affect retention, but one example comes from a survey of chief financial officers on the impact of these issues in their firms. In this survey, work-life flexibility efforts were seen as creating significant retention, recruitment, and productivity results. This study illustrates that how organizations address jobs can drive retention efforts.

2.4. Rewards: Compensation, Benefits, and Performance

The tangible rewards that people receive for working come in the form of pay, incentives, and benefits. Employees often cite better pay or benefits as the reason for leaving one employer for another. Employers do best if they offer competitive pay and benefits, which means they must be close to what other employers are providing and what individuals believe to be consistent with their capabilities, experience, and performance. If compensation is not close, often defined as within 10% to 15% of the “market” rate, turnover is likely to be higher.

However, the reality of compensation is a bit more complex than it seems at first glance. For instance, one study of public-sector employees identified that broad reward programs, not just pay and benefits, aided with workforce retention in difficult economic situations. A number of employers have used a wide range of special benefits and perks to attract and retain employees. For example, one media company added work-related plasma television screens, videogame players, and free soda and snacks as part of a special rewards package to create more positive views to aid in retaining employees.

Another part of rewards generally is that individuals need to be satisfied with both the actual levels of pay and the processes used to determine pay. That is why the performance management systems and performance appraisal processes in organizations must be designed so they are linked to compensation increases. To strengthen links between organizational and individual performance, an increasing number of fast-growing private-sector firms are using variable pay and incentives programs. Some programs offer cash bonuses or lump-sum payments to reward extra performance, which also aids with retention efforts.

Another rewards aspect that affects retention is employee recognition, which can be both tangible and intangible. Tangible recognition comes in many forms, such as “employee of the month” plaques and perfect-attendance certificates. Intangible and psychological recognition includes feedback from managers and supervisors that acknowledges extra effort and performance, even if monetary rewards are not given. For instance, one global hotel chain uses a

service-oriented colleague recognition program to engage its 30,000 employees. Different types of recognitions include “Star of the Month” and “Memory Maker” for significant service. For such recognition, a small amount of money (under \$50) and other types of rewards are given. An employee survey has shown significant increases in positive employee views of both their jobs and the firm.

2.5. Career Training and Development

Many employees in all types of jobs consistently indicate that organizational efforts to aid their career training and development can significantly affect employee retention. Opportunities for personal growth lead the list of reasons why individuals took their current jobs and why they stay there. In one survey, nearly one-third of workers identified the lack of career advancement opportunities to be the most important reason for potentially changing employers.

Training and development efforts can be designed to indicate that employers are committed to keeping employees' knowledge, skills, and abilities current. Also, training and development can help underused employees attain new capabilities. Such a program at one major airline has been very successful. Recruiters were reassigned to different departments, which resulted in their generating sales and revenues in flight operations and other areas.

Organizations address training and development in a number of ways. Tuition aid programs, typically offered as a benefit by many employers, allow employees to pursue additional educational and training opportunities. These programs often contribute to higher employee retention rates because the employees' new knowledge and capabilities can aid the employer. Also, through formal career planning efforts, employees discuss with their managers career opportunities within the organization and career development activities that will help them to grow.

Career development and planning efforts may include formal mentoring programs. For instance, information technology (IT) organizations are using career development programs so that IT individuals can expand their skills outside of technical areas. Programs in some firms cover communication and negotiation tactics, which gives the employees additional capabilities that are needed in managerial and other jobs. Companies can help reduce attrition by showing employees that they are serious about career advancement opportunities.

2.6. Employer Policies and Practices

A final set of factors found to affect retention is based on the employer relations policies that exist. Such areas as the reasonableness of HR policies, the fairness of disciplinary actions, and the means used to decide work assignments and opportunities all affect employee retention. If individuals feel that policies are unreasonably restrictive or are applied inconsistently, they may be more likely to look at jobs offered by other employers.

To ensure that appropriate actions are taken to enhance retention, management decisions require data and analyses rather than subjective impressions, anecdotes of selected individual situations, or panic reactions to the loss of key people.

The analysis of turnover data is an attempt to get at the cause of retention problems. Analysis should recognize that turnover is a symptom of other factors that may be causing problems. When the causes are treated, the symptoms can go away.

Some of the first areas to consider when analyzing data for retention include the work, pay/benefits, supervision, and management systems. Common methods of obtaining useful perspectives are employee surveys, exit interviews, and first-year turnover evaluations.

Stay interview is another feedback tool that has gained popularity. Defined as a retention tool to identify why employees stay with the company, it may also be used to ask questions about what motivates employees to perform. These and other types of one-on-one engagement efforts using active listening techniques are useful for HR to employ in measuring job and individual employee satisfaction.

The stay interview is an opportunity to build trust with employees and a chance to assess the degree of employee satisfaction and retention that exists in a department or company. Employees prefer to work in an environment that cares to know about and understand their thoughts, needs, and feelings—especially when they see actions take place following a series of stay interviews. Stay interviews are preferable to employee satisfaction surveys because they provide a two-way conversation and a chance to ask questions, and follow-up on ideas. They also deal with immediate employee happiness or concerns, not with how the employee felt last month or over the past quarter or the year.

3 Employee Survey

Many companies regularly conduct employee engagement or internal climate survey to assist in making accurate HR decisions for attracting and retaining employees. Employee survey 'season' is now in full flow and it's a great chance for HR to show their expertise and added value.

A well conducted and executed employee survey helps organizations create impact by increasing key focus areas such as employee engagement, as well as improving organizational performance. A poorly conducted and executed employee survey will damage employees' confidence in future employee surveys, as well as in HR.

Many of the most successful approaches to employee surveys are tailored to that organization, and there is no one size fits all versions. While each survey will require a different plan, this section aims to highlight some of the key aspects for consideration in the setting up of an effective employee survey process, and how to use that data in a way that benefits your organization and your people. Your organization's culture, employee profile, leadership approach and even geographical location will dictate the format and content.

1	2	3	4	5
Preparation	Communication	Implementation	Analysis	Action planning

The employee survey cycle. Barends, A. (2014). 5 steps to create impactful employee surveys.

3.1. Preparation

How to create impactful employee surveys tackles the preparation of your employee survey. Do you have a clear idea of your survey aim? Are your stakeholders involved from the start? Can you guarantee anonymity?

There are many things to remember if you want a successful employee survey. First of all, you have to have a clear idea of the aim of your survey. Secondly, it is important to involve stakeholders in the survey right from the start. Which method is appropriate to your organization? How should you draw up a questionnaire? And how will you handle the anonymity of the employees?

3.1.1. Determine the Survey Objectives

You carry out an employee survey to gain insights into your employees' perception of their work. The aim is to use this to make targeted improvements to your organization. Are your employees engaged? Are teams productive? What issues are important within your organization? Among other things, your employee survey gives you an insight into the

satisfaction, employee commitment, employee engagement, loyalty, motivation and customer orientation of the employees.

There are many constructs regarding the objectives of employee survey. HR professionals should distinguish among these terms as follows:

Job satisfaction defined as degree to which employees have a positive affective orientation towards employment by the organization. Employee satisfaction depends on company and administrative policies, supervision, salary, interpersonal relations, working conditions, work itself, achievement, recognition, responsibility, and advancement.

Organizational commitment has been defined as an individual's dedication and loyalty to an organization. Organizational commitment embraces the following three elements. These are (a) the acceptance of organizational goals and a strong belief in these goals (b) willingness to perform substantial efforts on behalf of the organization (c) having a definite desire to maintain organizational membership.

Organizational climate may be defined as "members' collective perceptions about their organization with respect to such dimensions as autonomy, trust, cohesiveness, support, recognition, innovation and fairness."

Job involvement is defined as the degree to which a person psychologically identifies with, and is related with the work motivation that a person has with a job. Job involvement is grouped into four diverse categories. These categories: 1) work as a central life interest, 2) active participation in the job, 3) performance as central to self-esteem, and 4) performance compatible with self-concept.

Employee engagement has become a widely used and popular term, and it has its basis in practice rather than theory and empirical research, while its construct often overlaps with other constructs, such as organization commitment, job involvement, or organizational citizenship behaviors (OCB). However, engagement is not an attitude; it is the degree to which an individual is attentive and absorbed in the performance of their roles. In HR practice, the concept is commonly seen as capturing levels of commitment and discretionary effort exhibited by employees.

In order to clarify the purpose of your survey, ask yourself: Why do you want to gain an insight into the work perceptions of your employees? Without a clear objective, your survey won't succeed and it won't lead to improvement.

3.1.2. Creating buy-in

As well as having a clear objective, it's important to create broad support for your survey within the organization. Too many surveys end up in the bottom drawer because the results are

ultimately not accepted or applied. To avoid this pitfall, it is essential to involve all the relevant stakeholders in the survey from an early stage. The aim is that various groups should be able to take action afterwards on the basis of the results. The support of these groups for the survey must be won in advance.

The stakeholders that should be involved in the survey from an early stage are:

- (Line) managers
- Other direct reports
- HR directors and managers
- Top management
- Executive Board / Supervisory Board
- Communication department
- Works Council (if applicable)
- Trade unions (if necessary)

It's advisable to involve works council representatives from the outset, not only to adhere to rules and expectations but also because a works council can play an important role in embedding the survey in the organization. If you work at an international level, get the branch managements/units involved as well.

3.1.3. Determining the survey method

When setting up your survey, think about which survey method is appropriate for your organization. This is also the time to consider whether you should implement the survey and the associated follow-up yourself or engage an external agency. There are three phases of the methodology to be considered:

- Distribution: How can you distribute the questionnaires in such fashion as to reach everyone with ease?
- Participation: What is the easiest way for respondents to participate in the survey?
- Data collection: How do you ensure that you receive the maximum number of responses?

There are many methods for conducting surveys. For a good survey of employees, two methods are widely used: via an online questionnaire and/or via a written questionnaire. Choose the method that best suits your situation and make it easy for employees to complete the questionnaire.

A good survey also leads to a high response rate. If, despite everything, you anticipate a low response rate, you might consider scheduling a time when all the employees fill in the

questionnaire together, such as the end of a shift. In that case, do make sure that an external person supervises it. Employees can address any question to that person. Moreover, this approach avoids consultation between respondents as the questionnaires are completed. If that happens, you will be recording group opinions instead of individual perspectives.

3.1.4. Guaranteeing anonymity

As well as a high response, you also want a reliable one. You want employees to feel free to give their honest opinion. Can you guarantee that employees will be able to complete the questionnaire anonymously? In the interests of anonymity, you should observe the following points at a minimum:

- Ensure that employees can complete the questionnaire where colleagues cannot watch them;
- Make sure that answers are received and stored on a secure server;
- Keep questions about personal characteristics to a minimum (avoid insofar as possible questions on gender, educational level, years of service etc.);
- Convert handwritten answers into standard (computer) fonts;
- When reporting the results, keep it at group level insofar as possible.

In addition, prevent situations where employees can fill in the questionnaire more than once. To avoid duplication and unreliable results, employees should only be able to give their opinion once. Therefore, be sure to work with unique login codes that can only be used once.

3.1.5. Designing the questionnaire

Keep it simple. The participation rate can be very adversely affected if employees are daunted by the time it will take to complete the survey or if they feel the questions are irrelevant to them. Employee survey questionnaires allow an organization to understand their employees and to see what can be done to increase their satisfaction, their engagement and their commitment to the organization. Employee surveys can be designed in-house or by an external consultant. If you wish to do your own, there are some steps to follow to ensure you will get the results you need to build positive employee relations to impact your business.

- Determine the need for your survey. Employee survey questionnaires can evaluate a wide range of topics including overall satisfaction, engagement, organization commitment, job involvement, pay and benefit perception, career advancement, supervision, communication, processes and policies, productivity and efficiency, job stress and work-life balance. The aim of your survey will determine the types of questions you will ask.

- Choose which questions need to be asked to get the answers you need to evaluate your employee perceptions in regard to the need of your questionnaire.
- Select the methodology you will use to ask your questions and gather your data. It can be both quantitative and qualitative. The way you ask your questions will be greatly influenced by the methodology you pick. It is possible to write an employee survey questionnaire that mixes both methodologies for a more complete evaluation of the situation.
- Decide which vehicle you will use to send the survey and gather the results. You can offer your employees multiple options or you can decide ahead of time that all staff members have to fill out the questionnaire on a paper format, via email, or via a secure online website.
- Proof and test your questionnaire before sending the survey to your employees. This stage allows you to ensure the validity of the result and that you will get the desired results. If the results are positive, you have completed the design of your employee survey questionnaire. If the results are not conclusive enough, start again and try changing questions or methodology until you have testing results satisfying enough to send the survey to your employees.

If the survey is to be taken by employees from other countries and cultures then it is best practice to have the survey items checked both for the accuracy of language translation and cultural fit. If possible, have a native speaker of each language translate so that the correct phraseology and wording is used to ensure consistency of meaning for each item. This is very important when there is a need to compare results from different countries.

3.2. Communication

How you communicate your employee survey to stakeholders, managers and employees has a dramatic impact on the response rate of the survey. Well thought out communication is key to avoiding resistance and a poor response rate, with practical steps needed to create a successful communication plan. Keeping your employees informed about the survey's progress, as well as clear communication in every phase of the survey are essential to its success. Promoting your employee survey to all the stakeholders as early as possible is a must for there to be adequate support, and having people involved from the beginning of the process will favorably affect the response rate.

If people feel involved in the survey, this will considerably increase their willingness to act on the results. If you do not communicate clearly with employees on important issues (such as information about anonymity), they may resist it. In the worst case, employees won't trust the survey and could even sabotage the survey by deliberately giving wrong answers.

3.2.1. Creating a project plan

A good communication process requires time, energy and experience and is vital to the success of the survey.

Before the Survey

All employees must understand why you are conducting the survey and what the benefits will be if they cooperate (i.e. 'what's in it for me'). You should promote the survey before the actual start of the project and let employees know what they can expect from the survey. Remember to clearly communicate the following:

- The start date of the survey
- The planning schedule for the survey
- The intended aim
- The guarantee of strictly anonymous participation
- The deadline for completion of the questionnaire
- The possibilities for asking questions about the survey
- How you will announce the results
- What will be done with the results

The more thorough your communication is, the better. You will find that response to the survey increases substantially and don't forget to thank the employees for their cooperation!

Start of the Survey

Whether you have opted for a paper questionnaire or online, all employees should receive a survey package. If you have chosen for a written survey, your employees should receive an envelope containing the questionnaire and an accompanying letter. In the letter you should explain what is expected of the employees and why. Don't forget to include an anonymity guarantee, and for further details, you can also include a pamphlet explaining the background and purpose of the survey. Completing the package by including the postage-paid envelope also makes it easier for employees to return the questionnaire.

For logistical reasons, it may be a better idea to issue the questionnaires on site. For example, you may wish to do this if you do not have the home addresses of your employees. In some sectors, such as retail and manufacturing, this is often the best method to get a good response.

If you have opted for an online questionnaire, you can send the link to the questionnaire by email. In doing so you can also provide additional information about the survey and anonymity in completing the questionnaire. If some employees have no email address, you can also opt to

provide login codes by written letter. If necessary, these codes can be made anonymous by means of a scratch-off layer.

During the Survey

Of course, you want to avoid any last-minute surprises. It's important to track the response daily while the survey is underway and address the following:

- What is the response so far?
- Which departments are showing the most response?
- How much time is there left to respond?

It's advisable to inform managers after three or four days as to how their groups are responding, which can be done easily by email. If the response is disappointing, you can resend the survey invitation and also encourage managers to remind employees to complete the questionnaire.

After the Survey

Share what the initial results are and what steps for improvement are going to be taken together with your employees. Indicating what the actual planning for these are will help you generate the right expectations with regard to the follow-up period. In addition, it also has a positive effect on the response generated during the next survey.

3.2.2. Designing communication materials

There are many ways of bringing the survey to the attention of others. Some possibilities are listed below, although you may have other ideas on how to promote the survey in a creative manner. Ways to communicate your survey include:

- Letter
- Email
- Flyer
- Staff magazine
- Posters
- Intranet
- On-screen pop-up
- Workplace meetings
- Short Message Service (SMS)
- Holiday card

- Introductory video
- Presentation
- Soapbox addresses
- Employee meetings
- Slogan

3.3. Implementation

You've prepared and communicated your employee survey. Now for the practical part—implementing—review the distribution, data collection, verification and the reporting associated with your employee survey.

3.3.1. Distribution of questionnaires

In principle, you should distribute the questionnaire to every employee. If you are conducting the employee survey yourself in a small or medium-sized organization (up to 500 employees), it is perfectly feasible to print the questionnaires yourself. If you work for a larger organization, it is often better to outsource the printing and distribution.

If you are using an online questionnaire, make sure you have a system that works properly. Consider, for example, having an email with a link to the questionnaire, plus the possibility to save what has been filled in so far and return to it at a later time.

Which questionnaire for whom? If you work with multiple business units across international borders and with a variety of cultures, keep in mind the differences that you will encounter. You should therefore adapt questionnaires to take into account the nature of the different parts of the organization. By customizing questionnaires for each business unit, you will increase the employee commitment across the entire organization.

3.3.2. Response period

The 80/20 rule also applies to survey response times. By far the largest response is generated during the first few days. Allowing 2 weeks for responses is usually enough, but if the response is disappointing, you can always extend the deadline by a week.

3.3.3. Data collection

How to get the completed questionnaires back to you? With a digital survey, this is simple. Written (paper) questionnaires can be returned to a freepost address. In view of the anonymity guarantee, we recommend that you designate a freepost address to be used specifically for the survey.

If the questionnaires are distributed on site, you could still use return envelopes but another option is to place collection boxes at the various locations. Sometimes, to promote a high response rate, it is important to offer employees the facility to deposit their completed questionnaires in a collection box as soon as they have filled them in. This can offer a solution for safeguarding your planning schedule, especially if you are centrally directing the survey in an international organization.

How will you recognize the various questionnaires returned by different departments? The bigger and more international your organization, the greater the need to draw up specific questionnaires. You can distinguish a questionnaire in English from one in German at a glance, but how easily can you tell the difference between one from the marketing department and one from the sales department?

It is therefore always practical to mark the questionnaires with a specific code according to surveyed group, for example per team. To maintain anonymity, write only the group name on the questionnaire.

3.3.4. Verifying responses

How to process the returned questionnaires? Processing data by hand is time-consuming and requires precision. You can save a lot of time by having people complete the questionnaire via the internet, providing you have set up a good system. In most cases the best option is to have your data processed by a specialized bureau, who can automatically import the completed questionnaires (optical character reading).

How to process open questions? Employees' answers to open questions, such as "What suggestions would you make for...", constitute an additional source of information. As previously mentioned, it is important that handwritten answers are converted to standard fonts to maintain anonymity. It is also a good idea to process the comments in such a way to not lose their content.

When processing answers, eliminate personal criticisms, you can also delete any coarse language, such 'creative' words frequently attract undeserved attention and usually demotivate the people involved. Revising open answers in this manner results in a more authoritative survey. If necessary, you can choose to distribute the unrevised versions among a limited audience.

3.3.5. Reporting

What should you mention in the reports? In effect, you should include everything in your report. Why was the survey conducted? What was the response? And of course, the results. Do keep it

concise. Be sure to substantiate the scores by including a statistical analysis of the results and displaying answers to open questions is important to help you get a better feel for the results.

How do you report? We recommend using graphics, charts for example. They allow you to see the progress that is made at a single glance. Use as many colors or icons as necessary to visualize issues that score well and to indicate areas in which improvement is required. Pages full of text do not inspire reading, and so, will not inspire action either. Try to divide the answers to open questions into as few categories as possible. When presenting the results for a group, make sure that you hold people's attention. Visualize the results, using images as well as text. After all, a picture is worth a thousand words.

At what level should you report your results? The survey pays for itself when stakeholders get reports that they can truly make use of. You should therefore attune the reports to the level of the various stakeholders:

- An A4 sheet with the main outlines for the Board of Management;
- A detailed report for HR;
- An action-oriented report for the business unit and/or the department or manager.

3.4. Analysis

The employee survey has been completed, and the data has been collected. The issue now is how to analyze the results: How should you structure the data? Should you use benchmarks? How should you prioritize? Taking care to correctly analyze your employee survey is essential in order for there to be impact. Without adequate analysis, your organization might address the wrong issues. The results of your survey should immediately disclose the state of affairs in your organization. As a rule of thumb, the data should therefore be structured to immediately reveal: the successes and the areas in need of improvements

3.4.1. Benchmarking

Whilst there may be some debate surrounding benchmarks, experience has shown that benchmarking is an essential addition to the structured data. A comparison of your results with those of similar companies or of the countries where you have branches can reveal valuable insights.

One of the questions you should ask is do you have good benchmark data? Much time is often wasted by drawing hasty, incomplete conclusions. For example, a subject such as remuneration usually gets a low score in an organization. After discovering the low score, you may come to the conclusion that you should act upon the low score. This however is not always wise.

A good benchmark can inform you where your organizations stand in comparison to others. In the case above, the benchmark could inform you that despite your low score, your organization scores better than many comparable organizations. Such insights can really help you decide where to take action, and further help ensure that you do not devote unnecessary time and money to an area where it is not needed.

3.4.2. Setting priorities

What do your employees consider important and in which areas is your organization's score (relatively) low? A statistical program is a useful tool in this prioritization. It enables you to measure the effect of each factor on various HR themes. In this way you obtain a list of priorities showing which aspects employees are proud of and which ones call for improvement. You can see at a glance where the priorities lie and which points have a direct impact on the way your employees perceive their work. Furthermore, it immediately becomes clear which elements make you stand out as an employer in the labor market.

3.4.3. Identifying trends

Compare your current scores with those from the previous survey in order to follow trends in the results. This will provide insight into the effectiveness of the improvement measures you have taken. Once again, communicate this clearly to the organization. This will show employees that the survey is having an effect.

3.5. Action planning

An employee survey only becomes effective when something is done with the results. To delve further into process issues: not telling employees the results of a survey is frustrating, but, worse, it tells them their input is not really wanted. That can result in disengagement, apathy, and “working by the rules,” not positive outcomes in an increasingly competitive and dynamic world.

The biggest challenge lies in ensuring that your organization takes action. But how can you ensure that there is action throughout the entire organization?

After your survey is complete and the results are in, you should begin informing people within your organization. It is advisable to consult with employees about how action can be taken, and to monitor the progress of planned actions. Finally, in order to establish whether the actions have really led to improvements, conduct a repeat survey and consider making an employee survey a permanent fixture in the calendar year.

3.5.1. Internal communications

Providing information in broad terms. Plan the initial presentation of the survey immediately after delivering the results. First, present the results to the higher echelons (directors,

Management Board or senior management). However, make sure that the setup has been approved by the project group before presenting the results.

What should you present? Show the facts and figures, but don't make an exhaustive list of them. Omit everything irrelevant, but make sure that you present the low and high scores. Where possible, make comparisons: comparisons with other companies, countries, teams and equivalent groups. Having heard the facts, the management will immediately want to look for explanations and causes, which is fine. You give the directors some 'homework' so they can discuss the results together and make concrete improvements. This is how organization-wide points for improvement are created.

The result presentation should last no longer than one hour, otherwise those present will lose interest. Moreover, observing this time limit will ensure that the meeting deals with the most relevant points.

Providing information at group level. After the meeting with the management, let employees know what form the follow-up procedure will take. Making clear arrangements will prevent the project from losing momentum. Think about who is responsible for giving feedback on the team results; consider when and how you will give feedback on the results at group level:

Consider where the responsibility lies for the follow-up. Taking action starts with informing the employees. Don't wait too long, and be honest. Employees will soon realize if you are procrastinating. The faster you show the results, the quicker something can be done about them. Don't stop at presenting problems, but also pay specific attention to the positive points. It is important that you carefully discuss issues that cannot be remedied with your employees. The report contains meaningful information, enabling you to discuss things together and then take joint action. At a minimum, you should inform all employees with regard to the following points:

- Response
- Important scores
- Points to be proud of
- Points for improvement

Consider whether to schedule extra presentations, for example to the (European) works council or the group managers. In some countries, the trade union is an important stakeholder; decide when and how you want to give feedback to all the employees.

3.5.2. Action planning

How do you ensure that immediate action can be taken on the results? The signal to take action should follow immediately after employees have been informed about the outcomes of the

survey. The basis was created at an earlier stage with a clear report available, for every level. The important thing now is to translate the report into concrete, well-coordinated actions.

- Decide who is responsible for drawing up action plans;
- Set a deadline for drawing up the action plans.

The responsible managers, project owners and team managers need to discuss the results. These are then discussed with the employees. Any uncertainties among the management members can be discussed at that time. The dialogue with the employees can be initiated per business unit or team in order to arrive at improvement plans at operational level. When that has been accomplished, the path leads upward again. You compare your plans with those of other business units or teams. Frequently, the same improvements can be adopted. You should also check that the improvement plans are in line with your organization's vision and objectives.

3.5.3. Monitoring

Once you have drawn up plans for improvement, it is important to monitor progress.

- Decide who is responsible for monitoring the action plans;
- Consider the extent to which the results and action plans are incorporated in the year plan and the evaluation system;
- Communicate regularly regarding the progress of the improvement projects.

3.5.4. Repeating the survey

Have the actions you have taken led to positive results? The next survey is the ideal time to establish the effects your investments have had and how much employees have appreciated the effort. If you establish the employee survey as a permanent instrument, you increase the likelihood that the results will continue to improve. As you gain insight, adapt the survey to include different or additional questions or action points.

4 Employee Focus Group

An employee focus group is a group of employees who are assembled to participate in a guided discussion about a particular topic or provide ongoing feedback. When used as a tool to improve employee engagement, employee focus groups typically leverage employee survey results as a starting point. A moderator will lead the group through examining survey results, open up items for discussion, and probe the group for potential sources of critical issues and solutions for improving employee engagement.

4.1. Why should conduct employee focus groups?

Employee focus groups are an easy and efficient way to uncover ideas for improving employee engagement. Employee engagement is the degree to which employees are fully involved in their work and the strength of their commitment to their job and company. Employees who are engaged in their work and committed to the company they work for provide a clear competitive advantage to that firm, including higher productivity, better customer service, and lower turnover.

Often the employee survey itself simply uncovers weaknesses and strengths, but it doesn't always point to action steps for improvements. This is the next part of the conversation and where employee focus groups can provide insight on how to improve employee engagement. Similar to surveying employees, conducting employee focus groups also communicates that employees' feedback is valued.

Focus groups may be convened on narrow topics, such as diversity management or career development. In one-on-one interviews, HR may seek to extract the same kind of information as the aforementioned techniques, or larger town hall-style meetings may be held in which executives respond to questions from employees.

4.2. Who participate in employee focus groups?

Ideally, all of your employees should have the opportunity to participate. Each group should have no more than 10-12 employees to ensure that everyone has the opportunity to speak. The best organizations encourage individual departments, teams, or locations to create their own employee engagement action plans and thus conduct their own employee focus groups. In addition, senior leaders can recruit for focus group participants to focus on specific topics for improving employee engagement.

4.3. Who runs an employee focus group?

The focus group moderator is a critical role, and those taking it on should be well trained on how to conduct employee focus groups and handle difficult situations.

There are as many different ways to survey employees as there are organizations in the world. The specific questions are not the most important thing though; the critical components are the actions that follow. There is no reason to waste resources on a survey that does not lead to change within the organization. Every company has areas of opportunity, especially when it comes to getting their employees more engaged.

The moderator should be someone who the team respects and looks to as a leader, but not necessarily be the group's manager. In fact, sometimes it's valuable to exclude managers from their team's focus group, so employees feel like they can speak more freely.

4.4. When to conduct an employee focus group?

Timing is dependent on how quickly you receive access to your employee survey results. Ideally, within one to two months after your survey closes, your leadership team will have reviewed survey results, shared findings with employees, met to discuss next steps, and rolled out reports to individual teams. At this time, employee focus groups should begin. These aren't one and done activities. Let the group drive itself, deciding if it needs to meet more than once and what its next steps are. A regular cadence of activity, such as focus groups, updates on progress, and pulse surveys will keep your organization on the path to improving employee engagement.

On average, employees who report follow-up after a survey are 12 times more engaged than those who don't experience follow-up. Simply following up, continuing the conversation, and asking employees' input for next steps improves employee engagement. However, the big impact of employee focus groups comes from implementing the ideas generated by your employees and actually improving employee engagement.

5 Exit Interviews

One widely used means for assisting retention assessment efforts is the exit interview, in which individuals who are leaving the organization are asked to give their reasons. HR must regularly summarize and analyze the data by category (e.g., reasons for leaving, department, length of service, etc.) to provide managers and supervisors with information for improving company efforts.

Exit interviews are structured discussions held with employees before, or shortly after, they leave an organization to gauge their perception of working in the organization. The real reason businesses conduct exit interviews is to get information about an employee's work experience with the company. This information could be valuable all on its own or used with other exit interview data.

An exit interview is an interview conducted when an employee is leaving with a company. Exit interviews can have value not only in terms of assessing and improving corporate culture but also in minimizing an employer's exposure in litigation.

Purposes	Principle
• Glean feedback from employees in order to improve organization • Minimize an employer's exposure in litigation • Retain high performers or talents	• Should be a neutral person (HR or a consultant) • Should provide a sufficient training for the interviewer • Should be a structure interview format that contains questions about unavoidable and avoidable reasons for leaving • Should prepare for each exit interview by reviewing the interview format and the interviewee's personnel file • Should be conducted in a private place, before the employee's last day • Should confidential and that only will used for retention • Should be aligned with the organization's business needs

Kaye, B. & Jordan-Evans, S. (2015). Hello Stay Interviews, Goodbye Talent Loss: A Manager's Playbook. San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers.

5.1. Who will conduct the interview?

Many companies have an employee's supervisor administer the exit interview. Not a good idea. If an employee had an issue with their supervisor, then chances are it will not come to the surface during the interview.

An exit interview is a meeting with a terminating employee that is generally conducted by Human Resources staff. The exit interview provides your organization with the opportunity to obtain frank, honest feedback from the employee who is leaving your employment.

Since HR is considered the keeper of employee references, employees may not open up to HR. At this point in their career, they don't want to burn bridges. So this becomes an exercise in futility. If you really want employees to provide open, honest and unfiltered feedback, consider engaging a neutral, third party to conduct the interview.

5.2. When do you conduct the interview?

Some firms like to do exit interviews at the point a person announces their resignation. Experts suggest that waiting not only until after a person leaves but even giving them a couple of weeks. Time allows employees to gain perspective. There have been many situations where departing employees were upset with the company or their manager. A couple weeks later, they still aren't happy but they're able to talk about it with less emotion. They are able to offer some constructive criticism.

5.3. What's the purpose of the interview?

An employee's need to leave on good terms drives their answers regarding their resignation. For example, when an employee tells you they are resigning and you ask why, they'll say more money, flexible schedule, less driving time, more benefits, etc. And all of that might be true. But what the employee didn't tell you was the catalyst that started them looking for a new opportunity in the first place. Something made them read the classified ads, take the headhunters call, etc. The purpose of an exit interview is to find out what that 'something' was.

If you want to improve the workplace and increase engagement, then create an exit interview process that yields good results. And include in the process a solid plan to review and act on those results. With solid information, you can incorporate positive change and, hopefully, reduce the need for exit interviews.

6 Employee Relations Programs

Employee relations strategies that promote a positive organizational culture are those that are aligned with corporate strategy while serving employee needs. For example, a company seeking to build a learning organization would not be served well by strict policies that discipline mistakes and subvert innovation. A company seeking to promote honest and meaningful communication to aid in problem solving may write an open door policy, but should also be certain to avoid the hiring of authoritarian supervisors who don't listen.

HR is responsible for creating behavioral guidelines for all members of the workforce, and for seeking constructive ways to solve conflict. Effective conflict resolution skills are a must for HR professionals seeking to support a positive corporate culture, as pervasive conflict affects outcomes such as employee engagement, morale, and commitment. Fair procedures to make decisions about promotions and eligibility for training, as well as for making compensation-related decisions should be developed and communicated.

6.1. Employee Participation and Involvement

When an employee participates in a business activity, it means he shares the activity with others. These others form one team with the employee and the team is responsible for completion of a goal or project. The team provides the forum where the employee can suggest ideas to make the item more efficiently and make decisions about his portion of the team's project. Whether the level of the employees' involvement is major or minor, all team members are encouraged to participate.

Employee involvement involves a one-on-one approach between the employee and management. This is a more direct method of handling a work project, as the individual employee is included in all aspects of the decision-making process. This process encourages an employee to take ownership of the outcome of the project. The employee affects the process itself by making decisions with management, which both encourages the employees to become more involved in the project and share their ideas on how to improve the project.

While employee participation fosters a team approach and the project is completed by a group of co-employees sharing the same goal, the employee involvement approach links the employee with a direct connection to management. This allows employees in the involvement approach to offer ideas regarding the project until a decision is reached. Both approaches can foster a strong sense of commitment to the common goal.

6.2. Employee Recognition

Employee recognition is the acknowledgement of an individual or team's behavior, effort and accomplishments that support the organization's goals and values. Employee recognition is a communication tool that reinforces and rewards the most important outcomes that people create for your organizational goals. When you recognize people effectively, you reinforce, with your chosen means of recognition, the actions and behaviors that you most want to see people repeat. Your recognition reinforces the employee's understanding of how you would like to see him or her contributing in the workplace.

6.3. Diversity and Inclusion (D&I)

Diversity means all the ways we differ. Some of these differences we are born with and cannot change. Anything that makes us unique is part of this definition of diversity. Inclusion involves bringing together and harnessing these diverse forces and resources, in a way that is beneficial. Inclusion puts the concept and practice of diversity into action by creating an environment of involvement, respect, and connection—where the richness of ideas, backgrounds, and perspectives are harnessed to create business value. Diversity and Inclusion (D&I) programs are becoming a key part of many employer's positive employee relations strategy every day.

Diversity creates dissent, and organizations need that. Without it, they are not going to get any deep inquiry or breakthroughs. The dynamic created by dissent prevents organizations from becoming too insular and out of touch with their increasingly heterogeneous customer base and as a result, working teams are able to come up with a wider range of solutions to business problems.

Further, an inclusive workplace that understands the needs of their employees, making them feel valued and respected has a significant and positive impact on employee retention. Perhaps most importantly, research suggests companies that openly articulate values of inclusion and have a diverse workforce tend to appeal to a wider customer and supplier base.

Diversity training is an essential part of building awareness and a cohesive work environment. Diversity training is an ongoing process to educate employees on the proper way to treat people of different backgrounds. The purpose of diversity training is to increase participants' awareness about individual differences in the workplace and how those differences inhibit or enhance the way people work together and get work done. This practice places a heavy emphasis on reducing the use of stereotypes.

7 Grievance Management

A grievance is a complaint that may or may not be justified. A grievance is a complaint that has been put in writing and thus made formal. Management should be concerned with both complaints and grievances, because both may be important indicators of potential problems within the workforce. Without a grievance procedure, management may be unable to respond to employee concerns because managers are unaware of them. Therefore, a formal grievance procedure is a valuable communication tool for the organization.

7.1. Grievance Responsibilities

The following table shows the typical division of responsibilities between the HR unit and line managers for handling grievances. These responsibilities vary considerably from one organization to another, even between unionized firms. But the HR unit usually has more general responsibilities. Managers must accept the grievance procedure as a possible constraint on some of their decisions. Management should recognize that a grievance is a behavioral expression of some underlying problem. This statement does not mean that every grievance is a symptom of something radically wrong. Employees do file grievances over petty matters as well as over important concerns, and management must be able to differentiate between the two. However, to ignore a repeated problem by taking a legalistic approach to grievance resolution is to miss much of what the grievance procedure can do for management.

HR Department	Managers
• Assists in designing the grievance procedure • Monitors trends in grievance rates for the organization • May assist in preparing grievance cases for arbitration • May have responsibility for settling grievances	• Operate within provisions of the grievance procedure • Attempt to resolve grievances where possible "closest to the problem" • Document grievance cases for the grievance procedure • Engage in grievance prevention efforts

7.2. Grievance Investigation

Employees should, wherever possible, aim to settle most grievances informally with their manager. Many problems can be raised and settled during the course of everyday working relationships. This also allows for problems to be settled quickly. If the grievance cannot be resolved informally, or it is of a serious nature, then the employee may raise a formal grievance.

Grievance procedures are formal communications channels designed to settle a grievance as soon as possible after the problem arises. First-line supervisors are usually closest to a problem; however, the supervisor is concerned with many other matters besides one employee's grievance, and may even be the subject of an employee's grievance. Supervisory involvement presents some problems in solving a grievance at this level.

The following steps should be taken as soon as the employer receives a verbal or written complaint, according to a leading professional association for human resource management.

1 Ensure Confidentiality	2 Provide Interim Protection	3 Select the Investigator
4 Create an Investigation Plan	5 Develop Interview Questions	6 Conduct Interviews
7 Make a Decision	8 Closure of Investigation	9 Develop Written Results

The nine-step grievance investigation process

7.2.1. Ensure Confidentiality

The employer must protect the confidentiality of employee claims to the best of its ability. At the same time, the employer has to conduct a prompt and an effective investigation. Therefore, it may not be possible to keep all information gathered in the initial complaint, such as interviews and records, completely confidential. The employer should explain to the complaining party and all individuals involved in the investigation that all information gathered will remain confidential to the extent possible for a thorough investigation. It should also be explained that to conduct a prompt and effective investigation, some information will be revealed to the accused and potential witnesses, but that information will be shared only on a "need to know" basis. An employer should never promise complete confidentiality.

7.2.2. Provide Interim Protection

One of the first considerations may be the need to take immediate measures for the protection of the accuser or the alleged victim. Separating the alleged victim from the accused may be necessary to guard against continued harassment or retaliation. Actions such as a schedule change, transfer or leave of absence may be necessary; however, complainants should not be involuntarily transferred or burdened. These types of actions could appear to be retaliatory and result in a retaliation claim. The employer and the accuser must work together to arrive at an amenable solution. Employers may wish to seek legal advice prior to making any decisions.

7.2.3. Select the investigator

The investigator should be in a position to maintain confidentiality, be respected within the organization (because his or her conclusions will be used to make a determination), have the ability to act as a credible witness and, if internal, have the likelihood of continued employment with the company. Employers generally use the resources of experienced HR professionals, internal security, legal counsel (inside or outside) or a third-party investigator.

7.2.4. Create an Investigation Plan

An investigation must be planned to be effective and properly executed. A complete plan should include an outline of the issue, the development of a witness list, sources for information and evidence, interview questions targeted to elicit crucial information and details, and a process for retention of documentation (e.g., interview notes and e-mails that could be treated as evidence).

7.2.5. Develop Interview Questions

Questions should be developed ahead of time in the planning stage, although additional questions will be added throughout the investigation as more evidence and information are shared. Good questions are relevant and designed to draw out facts without leading the interviewee; they should be open-ended to elicit as much information as possible.

7.2.6. Conduct Interviews

Once the appropriate investigator has been selected, an investigation plan has been developed and interview questions have been created, interviews can be conducted. The investigator should inform all parties involved of the need for an investigation and explain the investigation process.

7.2.7. Make a Decision

Through the investigation, the investigator must be careful not to jump to any conclusions before all the facts are available. Once the interviews are conducted, other necessary procedures, such as evidence collection, should be completed. Once any credibility issues have been resolved, the investigator will evaluate all the information for a formal recommendation. The investigator or member of management, as well as legal counsel, should make the final determination of any employment actions that are warranted based on the investigative report. The employer must consider all the parties involved as well as organizational processes, not just whether the accused is guilty, in the final determination.

7.2.8. Closure of Investigation

Once a decision is made, the employer should notify both the complaining employee and the accused of the outcome. It is important to let the complainant know that the organization took the complaint seriously and took appropriate action. The organization must ensure the

complainant agrees that he or she has been properly heard and understood, even if he or she is not in agreement with the results. The investigator should set a time frame to follow up with the complainant to ensure there are no other issues and that he or she is settling back into the work environment. The employer should encourage communication and follow-up until the complainant is comfortable again. Finally, the investigator should remind all parties to preserve confidentiality as appropriate. When necessary, employers must take corrective action that is appropriate to the situation, such as discipline or even termination.

7.2.9. Develop Written Results

If operating on the premise that every investigation of a serious nature could potentially be heard and reviewed by a court, the employer should consider preparing a final investigative report. The organization should keep a clear paper trail of the evidence, such as examining documentation of previous employee behavior and incidents. The investigator should have a clear record of everything done and any findings as well as other steps taken during the investigation. Employers should also document interviews with the accused, the accuser and witnesses. Investigators should ensure their notes from interviews are as factual as possible, contain as much relevant information as possible, are dated and indicate the duration and time of the interviews.

7.3. Grievance Arbitration

Grievance arbitration is a means by which disputes arising from different interpretations of a labor contract are settled by a third party. This should not be confused with contract or issues arbitration, discussed earlier, when arbitration is used to determine how a contract will be written.

Grievance arbitration presents several problems. It has been criticized as being too costly, too legalistic, and too time-consuming. One study found that arbitrators generally treated women more leniently than men in disciplinary grievance situations. In addition, many feel that there are too few qualified and experienced arbitrators. Despite these problems, arbitration has been successful and is currently seen as a potentially superior solution to traditional approaches to resolving union-management problems.

8 Alternative Dispute Resolution

Sometimes problems are easier to solve when an impartial person helps create the solution. Therefore, at various points in the discipline process, the employee or organization might want to bring in someone to help with problem solving. Rather than turning to the courts every time an outsider is desired, more and more organizations are using alternative dispute resolution (ADR). A variety of ADR techniques show promise for resolving disputes in a timely, constructive, cost-effective manner as below:

ADR

- › Open-door policy
- › Peer review
- › Mediation
- › Arbitration

Noe, R.A., Hollenbeck, J.R., Gerhart, B., & Wright, P.M. (2018) Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (Seventh Edition). New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.

8.1. Open-door policy

Based on the expectation that two people in conflict should first try to arrive at a settlement together, the organization has a policy of making managers available to hear complaints. Typically, the first “open door” is that of the employee's immediate supervisor, and if the employee does not get a resolution from that person, the employee may appeal to managers at higher levels. This policy works only to the degree that employees trust management and managers who hear complaints listen and are able to act.

8.2. Peer review

The people in conflict take their conflict to a panel composed of representatives from the organization at the same levels as the people in the dispute. The panel hears the case and tries to help the parties arrive at a settlement. To set up a panel to hear disputes as they arise, the organization may assign managers to positions on the panel and have employees elect non-management panel members.

8.3. Mediation

A neutral party from outside the organization hears the case and tries to help the people in conflict arrive at a settlement. The process is not binding, meaning the mediator cannot force a solution.

8.4. Arbitration

A professional arbitrator from outside the organization hears the case and resolves it by making a decision. Most arbitrators are experienced employment lawyers or retired judges. The employee and employer both have to accept this person's decision.

Typically, an organization's ADR process begins with an open-door policy, which is the simplest, most direct, and least expensive way to settle a dispute. When the parties to a dispute cannot resolve it themselves, the organization can move the dispute to peer review, mediation, or arbitration. At some organizations, if mediation fails, the process moves to arbitration as a third and final option. Although arbitration is a formal process involving an outsider, it tends to be much faster, simpler, and more private than a lawsuit.

9 Workforce Reduction

Part Two: Employee Separation

Workforce Reduction occurs when employer institutes a mass termination of employees in efforts to reduce costs. Workforce reduction is also known as downsizing or reductions in force (RIF).

1 Reasons – Cost – Technology – M&A – Offshoring	2 Methods – Redundancy – Attrition	3 Process – Assessment – Severance
4 Employee Rights		

Downsizing: reasons, methods, process, and employee rights

9.1. Reasons of Downsizing

Workforce reduction may occur for several reasons, including changes in economic markets, poor management, or other factors. Since workforce reductions usually involve a large amount of employees, employers need to exercise caution and foresight when planning such reductions.

The primary reason organizations engage in downsizing is to promote future competitiveness. According to surveys, they do this by meeting four objectives:

9.1.1. Reducing costs

Labor is a large part of a company's total costs, so downsizing is an attractive place to start cutting costs.

9.1.2. Replacing labor with technology

Closing outdated factories, automating, or introducing other technological changes reduces the need for labor. Often, the labor savings outweigh the cost of the new technology

9.1.3. Merger and acquisitions (M&A)

When organizations combine, they often need less bureaucratic overhead, so they lay off managers and some professional staff members.

9.1.4. Moving to more economical locations

Some organizations move from one area to another. When the relocation of a business process is moved from one country to another, called offshoring, typically an operational process, such as manufacturing, or supporting processes, such as accounting. The economic logic is to reduce costs, sometimes called labor arbitrage, to improve corporate profitability. Jobs are added in the destination country providing the goods or services (generally a lower-cost labor country), but are subtracted in the higher-cost labor country.

9.2. Methods of Downsizing

While workforce reduction typically involves permanent termination of employment, it involve different methods as below:

9.2.1. Redundancy

Redundancy would be the means available to exit employees from an organization whose positions are declared surplus and redeployment opportunities within the organization have been exhausted. Redundancies occur during; restructures and reorganization following a merger or takeover; when business or functions are relocated interstate/overseas and/or when new technology is introduced or as a result of business closures.

Redundancies can be the fastest and most effective way organizations realize savings targets. Since workforce reductions usually involve a large amount of employees, employers need to exercise caution and foresight when planning such reductions.

9.2.2. Attrition

Attrition strategy works on the basis that position savings are realized through the non-filling of vacancies when an employee resigns or retires. Applying an attrition strategy to reduce labor costs would require an extremely disciplined and structured approach to making decisions to either not fill positions and/or to redeploy employees into higher priority positions from lesser priority positions as they become available. Back-filling of vacated positions do not occur. The surplus position once held by an employee who has subsequently left the organization is wiped off the 'core establishment' resulting in a reduction in labor costs.

For significant savings to be realized through this strategy, departures would need to occur across higher salaried positions and at significantly higher attrition rates. Organizations with low attrition rates are less likely to benefit from such a strategy.

Some organizations are tempted to apply a harder approach to the attrition model. This is where employees in positions declared surplus are placed in project related roles and redeployed into vacant and new positions if and when they become available. This is an incredibly risking strategy likely to affect engagement and overall productivity and could be

seen as constructive dismissal. The true cost of such an approach exceeds any costs associated with redundancies and organizations should think twice before applying such an approach.

9.3. Process of Downsizing

Workforce reduction or downsizing typically involves a two-step process, which may take anywhere from several weeks to several months or longer.

9.3.1. Assessment

Employees are selected and assessed for possible termination. Selection may be based on the employee's performance, although the termination usually depends on the company's individual needs and budget. The employees are then fired according to the selection and assessment process.

9.3.2. Severance

After or during the termination process, employees may be offered benefits which serve to ease the transition period after termination. For example, an employer may choose to provide severance packages or unemployment compensation. Also, some employers provide "outplacement services." These are services and counseling intended to assist the former employer in securing another job after termination.

9.4. Employee Rights in Downsizing

In most cases, employment is done on an at-will employment basis, meaning that the employee may be terminated at any point, for any reason, so long as the termination is not illegal. Thus, employees who work on an at-will basis may be terminated in connection with downsizing or workforce reduction. However, even at-will employees have certain rights that protect them if they will be subject to workforce reduction.

One of the most important rights that employees have is the right to be free from employment discrimination during termination processes. An employer may not discriminate against protected classes of persons when they implement downsizing. For example, if an employer only terminates a certain age group, they may be liable for employment discrimination. They may even be held liable if the downsizing unintentionally causes an unfair outcome with regards to a protected group.

10 Progressive Discipline

Progressive discipline is a process for dealing with job-related behavior that does not meet expected and communicated performance standards. The primary purpose of progressive discipline is to assist the employee to understand that a performance problem or opportunity for improvement or correct exists.

The process features a series of increasingly formal efforts to provide feedback to the employee so that he or she can correct the problem.

The goal of progressive discipline is to get the employee's attention so that he or she understands that employee performance improvement is essential if they want to remain employed.

The process of progressive discipline is not intended as a punishment for an employee, but to assist the employee to overcome performance problems and satisfy job expectations. Progressive discipline is most successful when it assists an individual to become an effectively performing member of the organization.

Under most circumstances, never move beyond the written verbal warning stage because they either improve or seek employment elsewhere. Failing that, progressive discipline enables the organization do fairly, and with substantial documentation, terminate the employment of employees who are ineffective and unwilling to improve. Typical steps in a progressive discipline system may include:

1 Informal Verbal Warning	2 Formal Verbal Warning	3 Written Warning	4 Termination
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Typical steps in a progressive discipline system

10.1. Informal Verbal Warning

An informal warning is when an employee is verbally told to correct the behavior. Informal warnings are always documented but do not go into the employee's personnel file as a formal notice. Remember, if it isn't written down, then it didn't happen. It is recommended that supervisors keep a notebook to write down conversations with employees to be referenced later, whether for disciplinary reasons, to celebrate later improvement,

This informal conversation is a great opportunity to address the issue while giving the employee an opportunity to correct the issue. Depending on the relationship between a supervisor and employee, it also gives the employee a chance to explain any factors, whether from their personal life, or in the workplace, that might be impacting their performance. Utilizing this

informal step allows the conversation to be constructive and informative and not feel punitive for the employee, which makes it more likely that they will happily correct the issue moving forward.

10.2. Formal Verbal Warning

A formal verbal warning occurs when the employee begins to show a pattern of negative behavior or a rule has been violated. This verbal warning should be documented and may be placed in the employee's personnel file. The oral warning should include disciplinary actions that will follow if behavior does not improve as well as a follow up date.

When making a formal verbal warning, the supervisor should make sure to communicate the process that will lead to the employee improving their behavior. This should include affirming that they are available to support the employee, and that they truly want the employee to improve. This will help the employee move forward and feel motivated instead of punished.

Follow up should occur in either one week or a month depending on the specific behavior. At the follow up meeting, the employee should be told whether or not sufficient improvement or change has occurred. If the employee has successfully made the changes you discussed, then make sure to recognize the work they put into this.

10.3. Written Warning

If there has been insufficient improvement or change, you should go to the next step of the process—a written warning. A written warning is used to make record of the violation that has occurred as well as the warning you have given to the employee regarding the behavior or rule violation. This should be placed in the employee's personnel file.

Depending on the specific behavior, an employee may receive one written warning or multiple written warnings. As with a formal verbal warning, each written warning should include disciplinary actions that will follow if behavior does not improve as well as a follow up date.

Like a formal verbal warning, a written warning should also come with communication between the employee and supervisor that lays out a plan for improvement. Receiving this kind of discipline can feel defeating to many employees, so it is also a good idea for the supervisor to encourage the employee while discussing this plan, especially highlighting the employee's strengths and why the supervisor believes that improvement is attainable.

In addition, a written warning should include an expiration date. This is the time frame in which the written warning will remain active in the employee's personnel file. This is typically six months to one year, depending on the severity of the offense. Ideally, the Manager, Supervisor and Employee should all sign and date the written warning as acknowledgement of the warning

and the plan set forth to improve behavior. This is your agreement with the employee to work together in order to right the situation for the good of everyone involved.

10.4. Termination

If the other steps of progressive discipline fail to correct an employee's behavior, or in the case of especially serious violations, the final stage of progressive discipline is termination.

Termination typically results when all other disciplinary steps fail to correct the behavior. It is unfortunate when this step becomes necessary, especially after working with the employee to make changes. However, it is still better to know the employee was given chances to succeed, and that termination was necessary than to be unsure.

Progressive discipline is a process, not a single meeting or document. The ultimate goal should always be to correct the problem and improve the employee's performance. In ideal circumstances, this process should be more instructional than punitive. The only way to do this is to check in often on the status of the improvement plan and work closely with the employee to ensure a positive outcome. You need to stay involved until the problem is solved.

11 Managing Workplace Behaviors

An important step in managing workplace behaviors is to understand the difference between 'culpable' and 'non culpable' activities, and that each is dealt with in very different ways. 'Culpable' behaviors are disciplinary; 'non culpable' behaviors are not.

1 Culpable Behaviors – Culpable – Non-culpable	2 Absenteeism – Innocent absenteeism – Culpable absenteeism	3 Aggressive Behaviors – Bullying – Harassment – Physical violence
4 Workplace Conflict – Productive – Destructive	5 Substance Abuse – Alcohol – Illegal drug	

Categories of workplace behaviors HR must manage

11.1. Culpable Behaviors

Culpable behaviors are those in which the employee is in control and responsible for their actions. Some examples include calling in sick when they are not, choosing to not perform their duties well or at all, willful disregard for safety measures, or instances of theft. It is essentially when the employee knows what the expectations are in any given area and is capable of meeting them, but chooses not to.

Non-culpable is just the opposite – the employee is not blameworthy. Legitimate absences due to illness or injury, poor performance due to an employee's own inability or to a lack of resources needed to do the work, or an employee's personal issues interfering with their ability to be effective in the workplace are some examples that would fall into this category.

When dealing with non-culpable behaviors, where the employee may not be responsible, the approach is different. Your goal is to find a solution to address the problem and to coach and support the employee so they are able to meet the expectations you have set for them.

Open communication is important and where there is a concern, and by speaking with your staff when concerns arise, you may be able to get a sense of what is affecting their performance. By trying to find a mutually agreeable solution and providing support and understanding, you will likely gain not only a loyal and appreciative employee, but a great performing one as well.

11.2. Absenteeism

Employee Absenteeism is the absence of an employee from work. It's a major problem faced by almost all employers of today. Employees are absent from work and thus the work suffers. This

indicator is for measuring the average absenteeism rate per employee, as a % of the total working days - Total number of absent days per employee/ total number of working days x 100.

Absenteeism of employees from work leads to back logs, piling of work and thus work delay.

Absenteeism is of two types:

11.2.1. Innocent absenteeism

This absenteeism is one in which the employee is absent from work due to genuine cause or reason. It may be due to his illness or personal family problem or any other real reason

11.2.2. Culpable Absenteeism

This absenteeism is one in which a person is absent from work without any genuine reason or cause. He may be pretending to be ill or just wanted a holiday and stay at home. The employers have got every right to enquire as to why an employee is absent from work. If an employee is absent because of illness he should be able to produce a doctor's letter as and when demanded.

When an employee gets absent to work without giving any intimation in advance or any information shall be treated as unauthorized absenteeism. Facts behind absent of employee may be genuine like having sudden health issues, any family issues or any family obligations which cannot be skipped. Before taking any decision on unauthorized absenteeism by employee, employer must know the facts or reasons which insisted employee get absent to work. If employee is terminated from job for the reason of unauthorized absenteeism without knowing any facts or reasons behind, shall be treated as wrongful termination.

A wrongful termination, also known as a wrongful discharge or a wrongful dismissal, is a legal term that describes a situation where an employee was fired and the reason for the firing appears to be against the law. Specifically, wrongful termination usually involves a breach of the employment contract or breaks labor laws in many countries.

11.3. Aggressive Behaviors

Aggression is any act a person takes to harm another. It can include any act in the workplace from verbal or emotional harm to physical harm and homicide. This can include coworkers, current employers, past employers, or anyone else in the workplace including customers, clients, and contractors. Aggression in the workplace can be any combination of verbal and physical or direct and indirect or active and passive.

11.3.1. Bullying

Bullying must always be formally reported. Unlike conflict, bullying is not a "two-way street." The bully is largely responsible for the situation and thus is responsible for any changes required. In cases of bullying, intervention is always required to guarantee not just the physical, emotional or

psychological safety of the target, but also to legally safeguard your business. Bullies need to be told that their behavior is not acceptable and will not be tolerated; appropriate investigative and disciplinary action, if required, will follow any such report. As well, the targets of the bullying require support and reassurance, understanding that they did not cause the bullying and are not to blame. All employees need to know that bullying is not acceptable workplace behavior and that any suspected incidents must be reported to the appropriate supervisor/manager without retribution.

11.3.2. Harassment

The definition of harassment outlines that the behavior is similar by its unwanted and hurtful actions. It can include unwelcome conduct such as verbal abuse, graphic or written statements, threats, physical assault, or other conduct that is threatening or humiliating, but the negative behavior is based on an employee's race, color, religion, sex, age, disability, or national origin. In other words, the distinction between bullying and harassment is that when the bullying behavior directed at the target is also based on a protected class, that behavior is then defined as harassment.

The employer is automatically liable for harassment by a supervisor that results in a negative employment action such as termination, failure to promote or hire, and loss of wages. If the supervisor's harassment results in a hostile work environment, the employer can avoid liability only if it can prove that: 1) it reasonably tried to prevent and promptly correct the harassing behavior; and 2) the employee unreasonably failed to take advantage of any preventive or corrective opportunities provided by the employer.

Sexual harassment is defined as 'Where any form of unwanted verbal, non-verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature occurs with the purpose or effect of violating the dignity of a person, in particular when creating an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment.' This can be divided into a) personal experiences of being subjected to sexual harassment at work or b) awareness of the existence of sexual harassment at the workplace.

Hostile environment harassment refers to a situation in which an employee's coworkers create an uncomfortable work environment, often through inappropriate sexual behavior or discrimination.

11.3.3. Physical violence

Workplace violence or occupational violence refers to violence, usually in the form of physical abuse or threat, which creates a risk to the health and safety of an employee or multiple employees. A leading international health authority defines physical violence as 'the use of physical force against another person or group that results in physical, sexual or psychological harm'. This can be divided into a) real experiences of actions and b) feelings of a threat of

violence. Physical violence can also be divided into a) personal experiences of being subjected to violence at work or b) awareness of the existence of violence at the workplace.

The most important component of any workplace prevention program is management commitment. Management commitment is best communicated in a written policy. Since bullying is a form of violence in the workplace, employers may wish to write a comprehensive policy that covers a range of incidents (from bullying and harassment to physical violence).

It's important that employers acknowledge workplace aggression and take immediate steps to stop it. If they don't, employees who act out aggressively know they won't be held accountable for their behavior. Employers can keep a worker's aggressive behavior in check by speaking with her privately and explaining why her actions are unacceptable and what the consequences will be, including termination. With aggression between specific employees, managers can call them in for a meeting and ask them to express their frustrations with each other. In addition, managers can encourage them to compromise or find a solution that benefits everyone.

Employers can sometimes prevent workplace aggression by identifying employees prone to inappropriate behavior. For example, if an employee consistently blames others when something goes wrong, he might be more likely to take his anger and frustration out on colleagues. If the company fires him, he might become convinced it was because others badmouthed or sabotaged him. Communication can often defuse potentially dangerous situations. When firing employees, offer an honest reason. If you're letting someone go because of poor job performance, explain exactly what caused his dismissal so he can't lay blame anywhere else.

11.4. Workplace conflict

Workplace conflict includes any type of conflict which takes place within a workplace or among workers and/or managers, potentially including conflict between employees out of work hours. It is a broad concept that includes several types of conflict that are normally treated separately, including employment conflict and labor-management conflict. Beyond those two subtypes, however, workplace conflict may not involve the employer as a party; a workplace conflict may be between two or more employees.

Conflict can often be resolved by the individuals involved, although this does not mean an employer should simply ignore the situation. Instead, be vigilant to ensure a final resolution takes place that those involved can live and work with. In the end, you may be required to help bring about a successful resolution if the parties cannot come to some kind of mutually agreeable way forward. Nevertheless, make sure that those involved understand the part they play, not only in the conflict itself but in its practical resolution. Ensuring that effective conflict resolution skills are part of your business's training and development program will support not

only you and your employees' ability to recognize and resolve conflicts, but will also promote an understanding of the nature of conflict.

HR need to have the courage to address interpersonal and relational conflicts that are destructive, and to commit to a culture of workplace civility. Most important, management must model the expected standards of behavior. Conflict can be healthy – and even welcome – within the workplace, if managed well and resolved collaboratively. However, bullying and harassment should not be tolerated in any shape or form. However, it is important to be mindful that conflict, if unresolved or not dealt with properly and proactively, does have the potential to intensify and take the form of bullying.

11.5. Substance Abuse

Substance abuse issues affect the work environment on many different levels, not only in terms of the performance of the affected employee but also the productivity of those around them. Encouraging a healthy company culture has wide-reaching ripple effects that benefit everyone involved. Aside from the obvious liability issues involving accidents, theft or injuries, substance abuse-related behaviors can contribute to absenteeism, loss of production, tardiness, poor decision making, interpersonal problems between employees and a higher turnover rate—all situations that can cost your company both money and morale.

There are many laws which provide guidelines on the policies employers can set regarding drug and alcohol abuse in the workplace. Employers can prohibit the use of drugs and alcohol, test for drug use, and terminate employees who are engaging in illegal drug use.

The most difficult part of maintaining a drug-free workplace is recognizing and confronting signs of substance abuse. Not only is it a sensitive subject, but employees may be fearful about answering honestly or addressing their own suspicions about a co-worker due to potential disciplinary action. Also, no one wants to accuse someone without evidence, and persons coping with addiction are often adept at camouflaging their issues.

If you suspect one of your employees has a drug or alcohol-related problem, schedule a private meeting as soon as possible. From a professional perspective, it's best to frame your concerns around job performance. That makes keeps the conversation relevant and less personal. Focus primarily on performance issues like missed work, tardiness and low productivity. Before you meet with your employee, gather information including attendance records, performance reports and observations of managers, and invite another supervisor to act as a witness and to provide support. Set the tone for the conversation by making sure your employee knows that you value and respect them as a person. Be cautious to avoid judgmental language while issuing your concerns, and give the employee an opportunity to explain while also being prepared for

denial or defensive behavior. Remember that they fear termination and may not be forthcoming in a judgmental environment.

12 Termination

It's one of the most unpleasant tasks that employers face: firing an employee. It's a task that employers must handle carefully, calling for direct communication with the fired employee and the company's remaining staffers. Employers need to explain clearly to employees the reason behind their termination and build a paper trail that protects them in case a fired worker files a lawsuit. Employers must also communicate with remaining staffers, briefly and in general terms, about what the termination means to them and the future of the company.

1	2	3	4
Paper Trail	Short, Clear Meeting	Explaining the Severance	Communicating with Staff

Mader-Clark, M. & Guerin, L. (2007). The Progressive Discipline Handbook: Smart Strategies for Coaching Employees. Berkeley, CA: Nolo.

12.1. Paper Trail

Before employers terminate a worker, they should take the time to build a paper trail detailing the reasons for the dismissal. This documentation should include any negative performance reviews, complaints from clients or customers and written complaints filed by supervisors. Such written evidence can protect the company if the terminated employee decides to file a lawsuit alleging unlawful termination.

In the case of a terminated employee, IT should immediately revoke all computer, network, and data access the former employee has. Remote access should also be removed, and the former employee should be dispossessed of all company-owned property, including technological resources like a notebook computer and intellectual property like corporate files containing customer, sales, and marketing information.

12.2. Short, Clear Meeting

When terminating a worker, employers should call the employee into a private office or conference room. Once away from other staffers, employers should immediately but politely tell the worker that he is being terminated. Employers should always include concrete reasons for this firing: The worker's job performance may not have improved. The worker may have been turning in shoddy work. Clients and customers may have filed too many complaints against the worker. Perhaps he violated company policy.

12.3. Explaining the Severance

Before ending the meeting, it's important for employers to communicate to terminated workers the benefits that they'll receive in their severance package. Tell a fired employee how many

additional weeks of pay she will receive, if any job training services are available and how many weeks of health insurance coverage she will receive.

12.4. Communicating with Staff

After the termination is complete, employers must then communicate with the rest of their workers about the firing. Without this communication, gossip and rumors can spread throughout the workplace. Employers should say that a certain worker was terminated, but shouldn't go into details about the reason for the firing. They should instead focus on future plans: Will a new worker be hired immediately? Is the fired employee's position being eliminated, too? If so, how will the fired worker's workload be dispersed among remaining employees? The more information about the future that employers can provide, the less likely it is that employees will form their own, incorrect, assumptions about the company's direction.

13 Outplacement

When an organization makes the tough economic decision to terminate employees, any assistance the company provides is appreciated. A severance package that covers two weeks, or more, of pay for each year that an employee worked and continuation of benefits for a period of time are the most common severance package components.

Heathfield, S.M. (2015). Outplacement Is a Service for Laid Off Employees. Available on humanresources.about.com.

Outplacement is a systematic process by which a laid-off or terminated employee is counseled in the techniques of career self-appraisal and in securing a new job that is appropriate to his or her talents and needs. It is frequently offered as part of a severance package; benefit packages may vary in length between three months to one year or, in some instances, until a suitable job is accepted.

Outplacement is a rapidly growing component of a severance agreement. Whether outplacement is effective in helping employees find jobs more quickly is up for debate. Experiences of former employees vary and employers appear to do very little vetting or measuring of the results of the outplacement firms they use.

13.1. Outplacement Services

Outplacement is a service that is supplied by companies that specialize in helping employees' job search following a layoff, discharge, or job loss. Outplacement services are contracted for by the employer who is laying off employees to help employees make a swift transition to a new job.

People can pay for outplacement themselves but it is a bonus when provided by the employer as part of a severance agreement.

Outplacement normally consists of individual or group career counseling and advising. Since many laid off employees are unfamiliar with current job searching techniques, training in job searching is provided.

Outplacement firms help develop resumes and cover letters and even apply for jobs for individuals. Outplacement firms also provide job leads and follow-up counseling and advice.

Outplacement firms supply offices for job searching employees in some agreements and group training in all aspects of job searching and career transition.

Increasingly, interactive outplacement services are becoming available online, so an employee does not need to travel to see his or her career coach. Additional outplacement services are provided over the phone, by instant message (IM) and even texting.

Outplacement services	Benefits to the employer
• Helping dismissed workers deal with the psychological aspects of losing a job • Retraining workers to develop skills that are in demand • Conducting personal assessments or vocational tests to determine workers' abilities and job preferences • Helping workers with job searches	• Ensures that future reductions will be less stressful and traumatic • Enhances the morale of those who remain • Enables employees to find jobs faster than might otherwise be possible • Reduces the threat of litigation • Underscores the organization's moral and ethical responsibility toward its employees

13.2. Benefits to the employer

The success of outplacement draws mixed reviews. Participants claim that too many people are served by too few career coaches. Others claim that the advice they receive is trivial and not very helpful in a serious job search.

Others are unhappy with the resumes and cover letters that outplacement firms develop and claim that they are boilerplate and embarrassing, especially when a candidate is competing with other clients of the same outplacement firm for the same job.

Otherwise, outplacement is still beneficial to the employer:

- Ensures that future reductions will be less stressful and traumatic
- Enhances the morale of those who remain
- Enables employees to find jobs faster than might otherwise be possible
- Reduces the threat of litigation
- Underscores the organization's moral and ethical responsibility toward its employees

In general, employers provide outplacement services to assist employees to transition to a new job. They are also constantly aware of the impact of their actions, how they treat laid off employees, on the minds and hearts of their remaining employees. Pragmatically, employers offer outplacement to protect their reputations as desirable employers, to head off potential lawsuits and, in the instance where a lawsuit is filed, look like good guys, and to minimize their liability for unemployment compensation payments.

Employers can use outplacement effectively to help employees bridge the gap between unemployment and a new job. The key is to utilize an outplacement firm that provides effective services for former employees.

Employers are advised to measure and track the effectiveness of the outplacement firm they use and to gather the opinions and experience of former employees who utilized the outplacement service.

There is a reason, according to a well-known business publication, why around 40% of employees, who receive outplacement as part of their severance, never show up to partake of the services. Some of these employees ask for cash instead of outplacement. But, the percentage of laid off employees who don't use the outplacement services, or quit quickly, is not really a wonder when you consider that outplacement firms, on average, don't even track the percentage of clients who find work before their outplacement programs end.

14 Employee Offboarding

An employee resignation always causes some disruption in the workflow, however, if the employee resigning is valued and you decide to let him or her work their final days, they can do a lot to make the transition successful. Here are exit/off-boarding activities to consider for HR when an employee quits:

1 Obtain a resignation letter	2 Require handover process	3 Provide required notices
4 Comply with final pay laws	5 Obtain company property	6 Sign non-compete or non-solicitation agreements (if applicable)
7 Notify key staff and contacts	8 Conduct an exit interview	

The employee offboarding process

14.1. Obtain a resignation letter

Ask the employee to sign a resignation letter to document that the employee left voluntarily and the effective date. Keep the resignation letter in the employee's personnel file. If you can't obtain a resignation letter, document the reasons for the separation and keep that record in the employee's personnel file.

14.2. Require handover process

Meet with the employee and his or her supervisor to determine the status of current projects. Create a plan to reassign the employee's duties, document critical work processes, and if time permits, train co-workers on key responsibilities.

14.3. Provide required notices

The applicable labor laws may require that you provide certain information to departing employees. For example, some countries require employers to provide a separation notice explaining the reason for, and date of, the separation for unemployment claims purposes. To be eligible for unemployment benefits, individuals who resign must generally show that they quit for "good cause," the definition of which may differ from state to state. Under the labor laws, you may also be required to provide information concerning health and retirement benefits, such as health insurance continuation. Check your government requirements to ensure compliance.

14.4. Comply with final pay laws

Under the applicable laws, final pay is due by the next regular payday, but many labor laws have stricter deadlines. Additionally, depending on your country or state, you may be required to include accrued, unused vacation and paid time off (PTO) in the employee's final pay. Check your state law to ensure compliance and keep a record of when you provided the employee with their final pay.

14.5. Obtain company property

Before the employee's last day, have the employee return any company issued property, such as uniforms, ID badges, cell phones, laptops, and building keys. Additionally, take the necessary steps to disable building codes and access to computers and confidential data. The applicable laws may place restrictions on an employer's ability to make payroll deductions for unreturned property.

It is necessary to involve IT in the employee termination process because a former employee who still has access to a company's network and proprietary corporate data is a security threat.

14.6. Sign non-compete or non-solicitation agreements (if applicable)

A non-compete agreement is a written legal contract between an employer and employee. The non-compete agreement lays out binding terms and conditions about the employee's ability to work in the same industry and with competing organizations upon employment termination from the current employer. Generally, the non-compete agreement states that the employee may not work for a competing firm for six months to two years following employment ending.

A non-solicitation clause typically restricts or restrains an employee's ability to contact present, past, or sometimes even prospective clients of the employer. Often it will prohibit an employee from contacting these clients for the purpose of selling them a product or service after the employment has ended. Breaching a non-solicitation clause puts both the employee and any new employer at risk of being sued.

14.7. Notify key staff and contacts

Prepare a list of the staff, key clients, and contacts that should be aware of the employee's impending departure. Explain who will be handling his or her work responsibilities in the future and identify a contact who can address any questions they may have. In general, avoid disclosing the reason for the employee's departure.

14.8. Conduct an exit interview

Turnover can be costly, and exit interviews are one way to find out why employees are leaving. To encourage candor, consider asking a neutral party to conduct the interview rather than a

direct supervisor. Based on the feedback you receive, consider what changes you can make to the work environment. On the employee's last day, wish them well and thank them for working for your company.

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